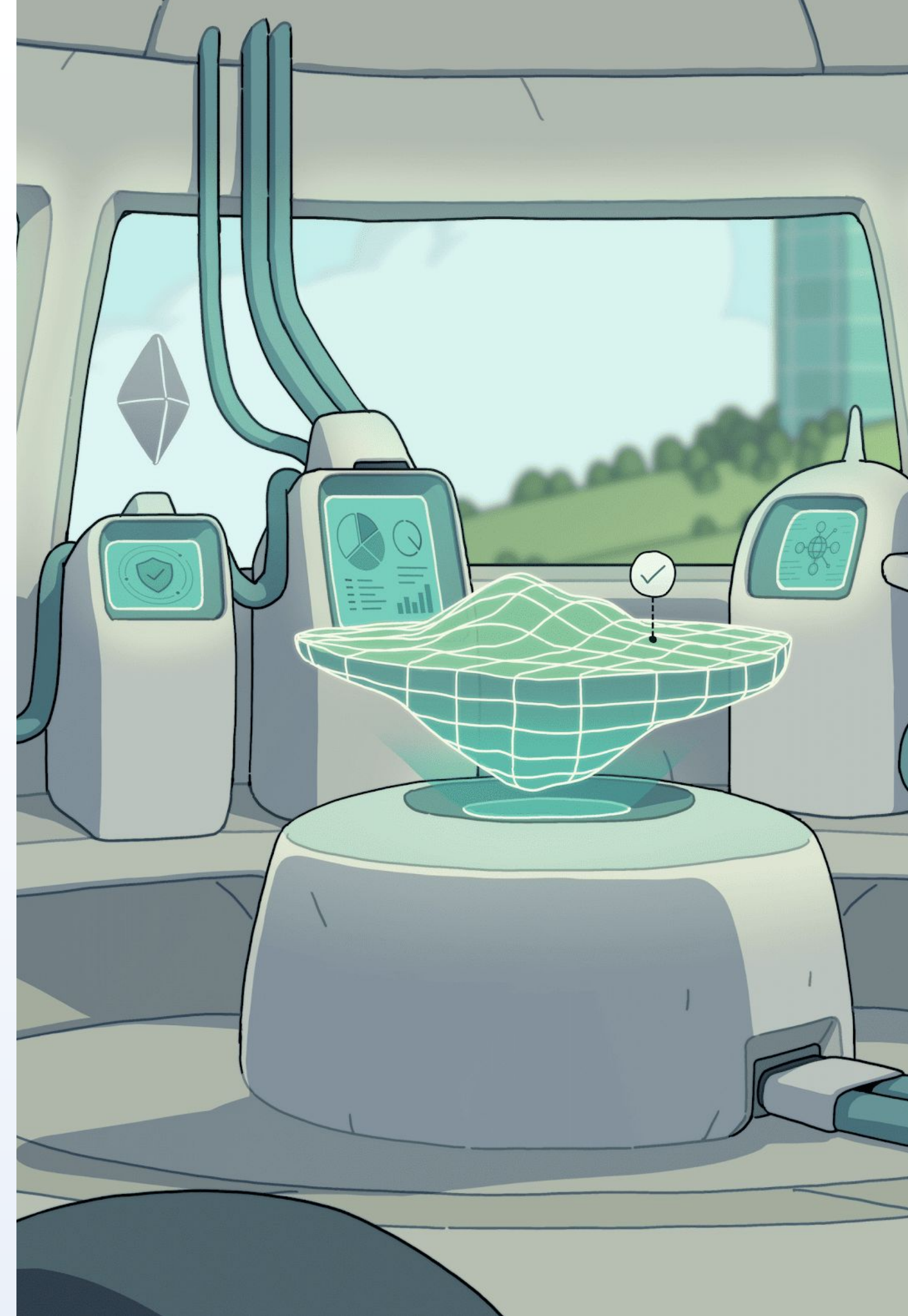




Apple in the enterprise

What 250+ enterprise IT admins say about AI, tooling, and managing Apple at scale.

September 2026





Mac administration in 2026 is no longer just “managing Macs.” It’s a full endpoint-management discipline involving identity, MDM, security, compliance, automated provisioning, application lifecycle management, and integrations with the broader enterprise environment.

“The challenge is making all of those pieces work reliably within Apple’s security and platform constraints while still giving users a seamless experience.”

— Survey respondent



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Apple administration is increasingly becoming an engineering discipline, and the people doing it are further along than the industry thinks.

Respondents describe a discipline that spans identity, security, compliance, provisioning, and application lifecycle. One of them explains it as full engineering work, not button-clicking.

They equipped themselves accordingly. 42.4% work with CI/CD runners, and 53% have declarative device management in production with another 26% piloting it.

For IT and security leaders, this data points to a problem that is easy to miss. These practitioners are generating and deploying configuration at a pace their current tooling was never designed for. 35.5% manage Apple devices through Intune, a Windows-first platform. 43% need more than 24 hours to roll back a bad configuration change. The work has changed. The infrastructure around it has not, and this report quantifies the gap.

"Mac management is *more complex than people think*"

— Survey respondent

KEY FINDINGS

AI assistants are the most used tool in their workflow

56.5% use an LLM assistant in their daily workflows, ahead of the MDM console itself.

Intune is the primary MDM for Apple devices

35.5% name Intune as their primary MDM for Apple.

43% need more than 24 hours to roll back a bad change

These are the same people authoring MDM profiles and scripts with AI. They generate configuration at AI speed and undo it by hand.



WHO WE SURVEYED

IT practitioners managing thousands of Apple devices

250+ IT professionals with write or admin access to cross-platform MDM and UEM tools who manage Apple devices in enterprise environments.

46.9%

Have 6 to 10 years of Apple admin experience

55.3%

Manage on average of 2,000 devices

7.6%

Manage Apple devices exclusively





Part one

AI, DDM, and developer tools in daily use



Tools used daily or weekly

AI assistants are the most used tool in their daily and weekly workflow



45.8%

A code editor

42.4%

CI/CD runners

38.5%

The MDM API directly



AI use in the last 30 days

AI is used most for troubleshooting, scripts, and MDM profiles

67.6%

Troubleshooting or log analysis

61.8%

Scripts and code

60.7%

MDM profile or configuration authoring

// Mapping to an open package Mac interface is much more realistic when controlled by a human engineer. AI does not seem ready or equipped to do this yet.

— Survey respondent. Not everyone is convinced.



How AI output is reviewed before it deploys

Only 13.7% keep AI out of production entirely

86.3%

deploy AI-written output to
production devices, after
review of some kind

13.7%

keep it out of production entirely

How they handle it

36.3%

Review and test
everything before it
deploys, always

28.2%

Keep a human in the loop
and route changes
through version control

21.8%

Trust it for low-risk tasks
but review anything
high-impact

11.8%

Use it only for drafts and
ideas, never for anything
that deploys

1.9%

Do not use AI for anything
that deploys to devices



Declarative device management

Declarative device management is already in production for the majority



3.4% don't know what it is

78.3%

In production or piloting

"DDM has replaced reactive scripting. Managing Macs isn't about running local scripts anymore. It's about setting autonomous, state-driven policies through MDM that enforce compliance directly on the client."

— Survey respondent



Part two

The MDM, and the time it takes to roll back

Primary MDM for managing Apple devices

Intune is the most common MDM for managing Apple devices

Microsoft Intune

35.5%

“Managing Apple devices requires a completely different architecture and framework rather than traditional Windows-style GPOs.”

— Survey respondent

19.8%

Jamf Pro

18.3%

OmniSSA
Workspace ONE

9.5%

JumpCloud

5.7%

Fleet

3.8%

Mosyle

3.1%

Kandji



Time to roll back a bad configuration change

Most cannot reverse a configuration change within an hour

69%

cannot roll back a configuration change in under an hour.

43%

need more than 24 hours to roll back a bad change.

26%

Same day, but manually

Even same-day recovery isn't a good position when it takes manual work. It is stressful, error-prone, and it does not scale when AI is generating changes at the pace this data shows. These are the same people authoring MDM profiles and scripts with AI assistants.

Part three

Apple's release pace, and the career trajectory

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**It's full engineering work, not
button-clicking.**

— Survey respondent

What is the hardest part of Mac admin work in 2026?

Keeping up with Apple's pace is the hardest part of the job

Most cited

31%

Keeping up with Apple's pace

A new OS every year, new frameworks, deprecations. Budget and headcount came last, at 5%.

19.5%

Managing personal versus corporate data

17.6%

Cross-platform parity pressure

13.7%

Passing enterprise security reviews

13.4%

Explaining the work to leadership

5.0%

Budget and headcount

Share of all respondents selecting their single biggest challenge.



In their own words · on Apple's pace

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Apple's ecosystem moves too fast for traditional Windows-style management tools and legacy IT thinking.

//

Mac administration requires the same level of security, automation, and scalability as managing Windows environments, but Apple changes its platforms and management frameworks much faster.

Two respondents, answering separately. Apple's release pace is the most-cited hardest challenge at 31%.

In their own words

What the rest of the IT world does not understand about Mac Admin work

"Mac management is more complex than people think"

"Mac admin work is complex and ever changing"

"It is a **real and hard work**, like other IT related work"

"It is no longer easy plug-and-play management. It involves enterprise compliance, zero-trust security and deep cloud integrations, just like Windows"

"We are constantly looking for new codes or software every minute of the day"

"How fast Apple updates its systems, and how much work it is to keep up"

"Macs in enterprise don't just work. Managing them at scale takes real engineering and constant adaptation to Apple's yearly changes"

"A single mismatch can affect the entire user experience"

Free-text responses to "what does the rest of the IT world not understand about Mac administration?" Lightly edited for spelling.



Career trajectory

Most describe a clear path from admin to engineer



- Clear path from admin to senior to staff engineer
- Some growth, but capped
- Flat: would need to leave to level up
- 2.7% are already senior or consultants

34%

Report capped or flat growth where they work

64% describe a defined route from admin to senior to staff engineer, which is itself evidence that this work now sits on an engineering ladder. The exception: 22.5% report growth that is capped, and 11% say the track is flat and they would need to leave to level up.



The recommendation

Move device configuration into code

The survey does not test this directly. Three of its findings point the same way.

60.7% author MDM profiles with AI

Every AI-written profile arrives as a diff

Configuration held in files means the change is legible before it deploys, rather than a console action with no record of what changed.

43% take over 24 hours to roll back

Rollback becomes a single revert

28.2% already keep a human in the loop and route changes through version control. Reverting a commit is a different operation from unwinding a change by hand.

86.3% already review AI output

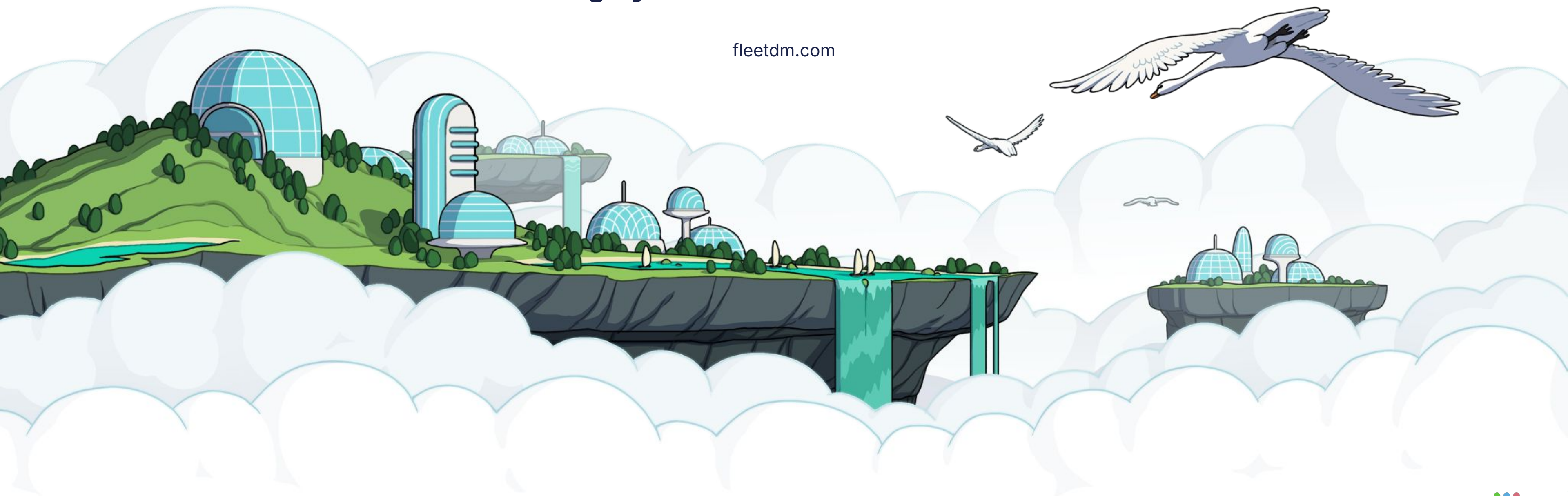
The review they already do becomes a pull request

The habit exists. Version control gives it a record, a second reviewer, and a way to hold at scale.



Manage your devices like it's 2026.

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